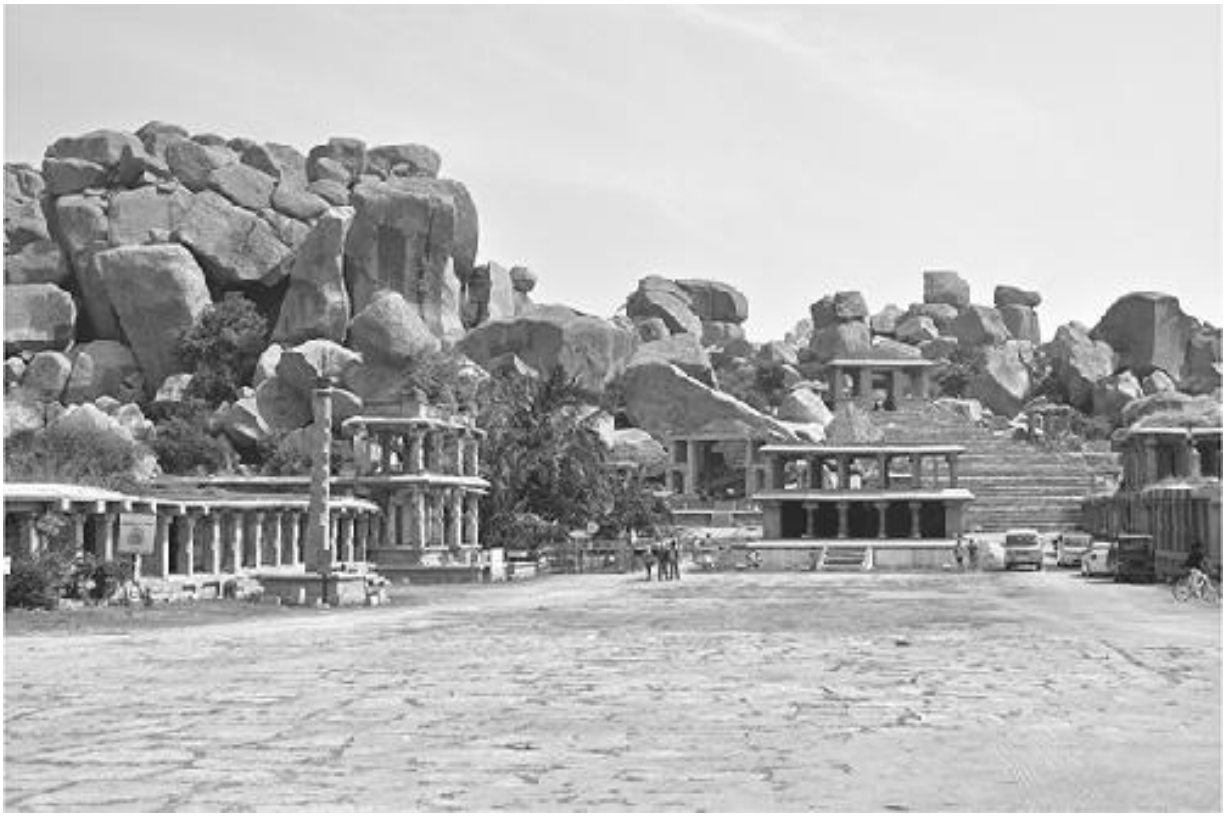


Figure 1. End of the Hampi Bazaar, across Virupaksha Temple

Indeed, the people of Vijayanagar were, above all, builders par excellence. Construction work must have employed large numbers. I imagine labourers, masons and sculptors doing the hard, back-breaking work of quarrying, moving, cutting, shaping and raising stones with the basic technologies of the day: chisel and hammer, ropes and ramps, human and animal muscle. Countless must have died in accidents. Fortunately, they didn't have to fetch stones from very far—their landscape had heaps of multihued granite boulders, which, according to geologists are among the oldest exposed rocks in the subcontinent. The city they built seemed to have dazzled all those who visited—as it does even today.

North of the river from Hampi, near the Anegundi village, are prehistoric megalithic burial sites, indicating that burials were once common here. There's also cave art from 3000 years ago, though its artists remain obscure. By the seventh century CE, a local cult had arisen, centred on a river